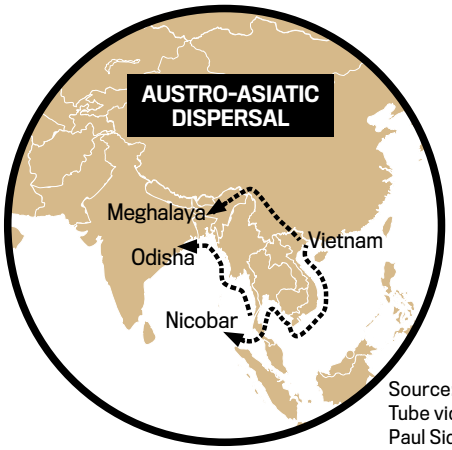
LANGUAGE

FROM THE MEKONG TO MALKANGIRI



Source: YouTube video by Paul Sidwell

Ethnonyms like Bhil and others figure in the old Indian epics, where princely figures encountering the forests is a recurring trope. And genetic studies confirm what archaeologists always knew: human presence on the subcontinent is as old and stable as a grandfather clock. The word 'Adivasi', a conceptual bundle expressing rootedness and genetic continuity, is a recent coinage spun off from 'aboriginal', though. We interpret that maximally because the actual history stretches before us like an *aranya* of the epics, deep and mysterious. But science has of late been throwing fascinating new light on one aspect here.

India's 'tribes' can be found among all our four major languages families: Austro-Asiatic, Tibeto-Burman, Dravidian and Indo-Aryan. Bhili, spoken by our most populous Adivasi group, belongs to the last named—and is thus in a kin group with Marwari, Gujarati, Punjabi, Hindi, Sanskrit et al. Gondi, the second largest, is Dravidian. Garo, the native tongue of Meghalaya CM Conrad Sangma, is part of a continuum of Tibeto-Burman languages called Garo-Boro that straddles the Northeast, sweeping in everything from Assam's Bodo to Tripura's Kokborok to the largest Naga language Konyak. (Despite the ethnic kinship, the 89 Naga languages are mostly mutually unintelligible; that's why they use Nagamese, a creolised form of Assamese, as lingua franca.) But the



The Bonda speak a south Munda language

INDIA PICTURE

HUL JOHAR!

There's a silent chapter in Indian history—or perhaps a whole library. Some of the fiercest resistance to British colonial power came from the tribal communities. Wave upon wave of armed uprisings, strung over some 150 years—from the **Chuar rebellion** in Bengal (1771-1809), and not ending with the post-WW-I **Kuki uprising**. If the bows and arrows of the **Kurichiyas** aided Malabar's Pazhassi Raja in his long guerrilla war against the East India Company (1793-1806), the **Bhils** of Rajputana rose up in 1818, and a series of **Ho** and **Munda** unrests led up to the **Kol**

